

SPOKES-PEOPLE



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Welcome...

to the first edition of Spokes-People, PennDOT's bicycle newsletter. The purpose of this newsletter is to communicate with and educate Pennsylvania bicycle riders about safety, laws and issues affecting cyclists.

New Bike Law

The new law requires motorists to leave a 4-foot "cushion of safety" when passing a bicyclist. To achieve this cushion, drivers may cross a roadway's center line when passing a bicycle on the left, but only when opposing traffic allows.

No turn by the driver of a motor vehicle shall interfere with a bicyclist proceeding straight on a roadway or shoulder.

The new law also calls for bicycle riders to use all reasonable efforts to avoid impeding the normal flow of traffic. When there is only one travel lane, bicyclists may use any portion of the lane to avoid hazards on the roadway, including maintaining a safe distance from stopped and parked cars.

As always, bicyclists and motorists should obey all traffic signs and signals. PennDOT also recommends bicyclists always ride predictably and signal their intentions before proceeding so that motorists have a chance to react.

Trails and Bicycle Routes Provide "At-Home" Getaways

With the summer vacation season on the horizon, families and cyclists are reminded that Pennsylvania boasts many cycling options including 120 state-owned parks, featuring 10,570 miles on 450 trails, as well as nine bicycle routes that allow cyclists to safely explore the state's scenery.

The trails offer a mix of scenery and history, and cyclists can explore trails like the Great Allegheny Passage, which begins in Pittsburgh and is the longest rail trail east of the Mississippi River; the Heritage Rail Trail in central Pennsylvania; and the Lehigh Gorge State Park in eastern Pennsylvania. Cyclists who enjoy challenging mountain biking have several options in the 37 miles of shared-use trails in Michaux State Forest in Adams, Cumberland and Franklin counties.

Cyclists accustomed to riding on paved roadways will find many options in Pennsylvania's nine BicyclePA routes, which cross the state on some of the most scenic roads in Pennsylvania. First established in 1999, the routes are clearly marked and maintained by PennDOT so cyclists can easily travel across the state.

Routes S, Y and V cross the state east to west, all offering unique scenic passages laced with Pennsylvanian history. Routes A, G, J and L cross the state north to south. Route G, which was the first BicyclePA route opened, offers breathtaking views overlooking the Pennsylvania Grand Canyon in Tioga County. Routes Z and E are shorter routes that highlight Lake Erie and the Delaware River Gap.

For more information on bicycling safely, trails and to see the BicyclePA routes, visit www.PACommutes.com.



PennDOT Ironman Knows Value of Biking

Daryl St. Clair, a division chief in PennDOT's Bureau of Maintenance and Operations, rides a bike. However, he doesn't ride to take in the sights – he uses his bicycle to train for Ironman triathlons.

In his day job, Daryl is responsible for winter operations, storm water, roadside and environmental management, and incident/emergency management. In his spare time he's training for his next triathlon. Balancing a disciplined training schedule with the responsibility he carries at work can be a real challenge on its own.

During the offseason, Daryl's average day begins at 4:45 a.m. He swims from 5:30 a.m. until 6:30 a.m., is at work by 6:45 a.m., runs six miles at lunch and works until 5:30 p.m. He's in bed by 9 p.m. so he can do it again the next day. Daryl rotates running and biking daily, so on bike days he rides after work for 90 minutes in his basement on a stationary bike. His offseason Saturdays include a 13-mile run and a nearly two-mile swim, while Sundays include a 30-minute run and a two-and-a-half-hour bike ride.



While the offseason training schedule seems intense, the weeks leading up to an Ironman competition become more rigorous. Daryl's preparation weeks include the weekday workouts of the offseason, but weekends start with a 25-mile, three-hour run every Saturday. On Sunday he goes on a five hour, 100-mile bike ride, followed by a nine-mile run. His monthly training mileage averages are 140 miles of running, 450 miles of biking and 22 miles of swimming.

"I like road biking because you go fast and I can bike inside or outside with the same bike," said St. Clair. "Also [biking] isn't hard on the knees. I have knee pain from running, but I am always able to bike."

All of this training has paid off. He's won five local triathlons and 31 other running races since 2002, competing in many locations like St. Croix, the Poconos, Lake Placid, N.Y. and Myrtle Beach, S.C. His best Ironman-sponsored event was a half triathlon (70.3 miles) in 2011 at Ironman 70.3 Pocono Mountains, finishing 99th overall out of 2,200 competitors.

This year, he'll compete in Rhode Island, Vermont and the Poconos. With each competition he hopes to get one step closer to qualifying and competing in the Hawaii Ironman, where the original Ironman competitions began.



Do Your Part For Safety



Last year in Pennsylvania bicyclists were involved in 1,316 crashes which resulted in eleven fatalities.

While bicyclists around the state welcome the introduction of the newest bike law, education efforts for both bicyclists and motorists need to be an ongoing effort.

An easy way for bicyclists to do their part is as simple as obeying traffic laws. Motorists who witness a cyclist weave in and out of traffic with total disregard for any law will naturally have negative feelings.

Be a good bicycle ambassador for your community by setting a good example. Ride responsibly, obey the laws and always signal your intentions so others can react appropriately.

Here are some other simple rules of the road to keep you safe.

- Be highly visible by wearing bright colors and use lights when appropriate.
- Always wear a properly fitted helmet. It should sit on top of your head and not tip forward or back.
- Be aware of traffic around you and be prepared to react.
- Make sure your bike is road worthy by checking air pressure, brakes and chain before you leave home.



Remember, bike safety is no accident.

Your feedback and suggestions are welcome at RA-penndotpress@pa.gov.